Great Zimbabwe Empire

The Zimbabwe kingdom was a medieval empire and situated in modern-day Zimbabwe. The capital of this kingdom was Great Zimbabwe, known for its large stone structures. Therefore, the origin of the word Zimbabwe comes from two possible terms which together mean "stone house." The kingdom declined in the 15th century but the stone constructions in the city are still standing. UNESCO has named the site of remaining structures as a World Heritage Site.

This location was inhabited in the 11th century when the people from Mapungubwe, who lived in southern Africa, settled in the Zimbabwe plateau. The land was full of new possibilities because the plains were vast and fertile. The people took advantage of farming, herding and various minerals such as gold, iron and copper. Thus, the location became an ideal place for trading. The kingdom of Zimbabwe was established in 1220 and the last records that could be found say the kingdom was inhabited until the 16th century. The territory of the kingdom extended from the Limpopo River and the Zambezi River to Mozambique and Botswana. It is also known to have covered the Transvaal area of northern South Africa.

The form of government in the kingdom of Zimbabwe was a monarchy. The Kingdom instituted a rigid three-tiered class structure and had more than 150 tributary headquarters in other minor cities. The kingdom of Zimbabwe established a bigger rule than the Mapungubwe, the Butuan, and the Mutapa. Not everyone agrees on the origin of the rulers of Zimbabwe. There is evidence that suggests they were also known as the Karanga, which is a branch of the Shona people. Pottery of the Karanga is also very similar to that of the Zimbabwe region. But there is another theory which suggests that the people of Zimbabwe descended from a community that lived in Kopje less than a hundred miles away from the location of Great Zimbabwe. Whichever they were, the first inhabitants made a transition from small farming communities to big stratified societies. By 1000 AD, the population of the kingdom was divided and ranked by status, from the higher elite to peasants who worked with cattle.